Cinema Is a Cat

A Cat Lover's Introduction to Film Studies

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CHAPTER 2

Cats Love Dark Places

Lighting in *Cat People*

Jacques Tourneur, USA, 1942

Breakfast at Tiffany's and *Cat People*

If *Breakfast at Tiffany's* is the story of a cat-like young woman, then *Cat People* is about a young woman (Simone Simon) who is, in fact, a cat. The story of *Breakfast at Tiffany's* closes with the happy ending of a young couple's marriage. *Cat People* begins with a marriage that is not really happy. While *Breakfast at Tiffany's* depicts the beginning of a couple's journey from a confined monochrome world to a liberated colorful world, *Cat People* shows the tragic failure of such a journey. One is a romantic comedy and the other is a horror movie; the former was produced twenty years after the latter.

Still, these two films are like sisters. Both are set in New York City. The heroines are non native New Yorkers and outsiders (Holly is from Texas; Irena is from Serbia). They are both haunted by the past (Holly was married to an elderly veterinarian in Texas; Irena believes that she is a descendent of the cat people of Serbia). In both films, young men fall in love with the heroines at first sight and try to save them. But both young men are engaged to other women, which makes for triangular relationships. While *Breakfast at Tiffany's* uses framing to emphasize Holly's confinement in small spaces, *Cat People* uses lighting to show the heroine's entrapment in dark places. *Breakfast at Tiffany's* makes us realize that the world of cinema begins in the square frame of the screen. *Cat People* makes us remember that cinema is made of light and shadow.

Cinema is a medium of light. It does not exist without the electrical light beam that passes through the celluloid strip to throw an image onto a screen before a viewer. Even before the process of projection, the production of moving photographic images was a construction in light. Without light,

the location, set, costume, and make-up, as well as the actors' expressions and performances, are invisible to the viewer.

At the very beginning of the history of cinema in the late nineteenth century and the early twentieth century, the primary purpose of lighting in cinema was to provide visibility. For instance, "Clarity first, story second" (*ichi nuke, ni suji*), the slogan introduced in the first decade of the twentieth century by Makino Shōzō, "the father of Japanese cinema," clearly indicates the importance of light and lighting in the early period of filmmaking. As the term *nuke* (clarity) suggests, what early Japanese filmmakers emphasized was not the expressivity of artificial lighting but the brightness itself, which would make images visible even in worn-out prints screened at theaters not equipped with bright light bulbs for projection. The priority was to make actors and sets visible to the audience. Hollywood films were lit in the same manner, making particular use of sunlight, until around 1915.

American filmmakers started to consider this style of lighting to be old-fashioned only a few years later. Most likely inspired by theatrical lighting, filmmakers became aware of the expressive effects of strong, weak, frontal, back, top, bottom, and side lighting, and the shadows that lighting creates. The impact of lighting is immense for the narrative, the atmosphere and mood of scenes, and the psychology and emotion of characters, among other elements. Inevitably, the use of light and technologies of lighting started to occupy the center of discussions in filmmaking. In April 1934, Earl Theisen, the honorary curator of The Academy Museum of Motion Pictures, wrote in *International Photographer,* the journal for Hollywood's cinematographers' union, "The most important of the dramatic devices of the motion picture is light. Light and shade are the most vital of the cinematic tools. Emotions are literally painted with light" (Theisen 1934, 10).

Cat People appears to be a horror film with monster cats. But producer Val Lewton does not make a film in which a fake monster ostentatiously appears; instead, he tells a tragic love story. The title sounds like a remake of *The Wolf Man* (George Wagner, 1941), in which a hero turns into a werewolf after he is attacked and bitten by a wolf-like creature of folklore. But in contrast to *The Wolf Man,* it is not really important in *Cat People* to show how the heroine turns into a cat person or to explain what kind of monsters the cat people are. Instead, the film focuses on the sorrow of a young cat person who happens to fall in love with a human.

Director Jacques Tourneur and cinematographer Nicholas Musuraca, in particular, responded with conspicuous use of lighting in this film. Early film theorist Rudolph Arnheim claimed, "[T]he use of shading does not necessarily originate from the observation of nature, and certainly is not always

used in accordance with the rules of illumination" (Arnheim 1974, 321). Tourneur and Musuraca emphasized that artificial lighting is essential to cinema. Constructing shadows with lighting, *Cat People* sensitively expresses the heroine's pain that the man she loves cannot understand what she really is.

Without any special publicity, the film became a word-of-mouth hit after it was released on Friday the thirteenth in November 1942 and stayed at theaters in Hollywood for thirteen weeks (Newman 1999, 64). Even *Citizen Kane* (Orson Welles, 1941), which was released in the previous year to great fanfare, played for only twelve weeks. Clearly many people were caught up in the fate of Irena, eloquently expressed in the play of light and shadow.

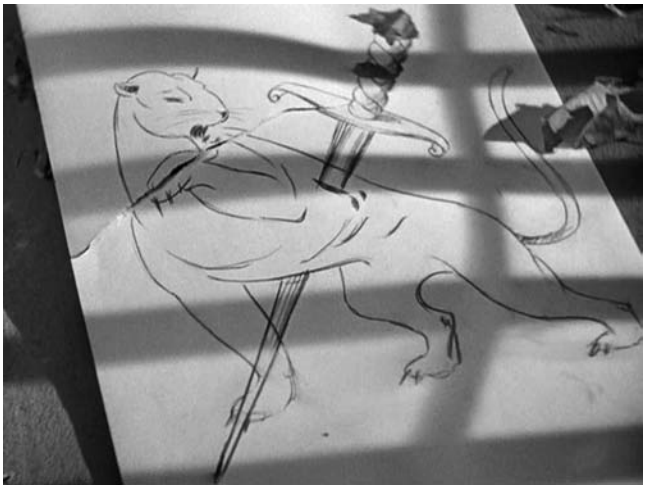
Irena Loves Dark Places: Three-point Lighting and Lasky Lighting

Cat People begins with a picture of a black panther. After the credits of cast, staff, and director, a cheerful accordion tune takes the place of the orchestral theme score. The tune is played at the Central Park Zoo, where the story begins. A black panther paces in a cage. As the camera retreats, we see Irena, the heroine of this film, eagerly making sketches in front of the cage. Her mouth is pointed and her eyes are a little separated from each other. Her face looks like a kitten's. Simone Simon, who plays Irena, was a French actress who had appeared in Jean Renoir's *La Bête humaine* (1938) two years before in the role of a young wife with a kitten.

Irena (Simone Simon) sketches a black panther at the Central Park Zoo.

Irena tears up a sketch she does not like and throws it toward a hollow tree stump that serves as a waste-bin. Oliver (Kent Smith), a young marine engineer, sees the paper miss the bin and warns Irena about it. It seems that both are favorably disposed to each other. But Irena does not seem to care for Oliver's moralistic advice: "Let no one say, and say to your shame, that all was beauty here before you came." Does he mean that the public morality of a human society doesn't affect cats? This scene of the first encounter between Irena and Oliver ends with a close-up of another sketch thrown away by Irena. It drops on to the street, is blown away by a gust, and stops at a fence. The sketch shows a black panther stabbed by a stiletto. The panther's cage, which is not seen on the screen, creates a dark shadow on the paper. The lighting, together with the score, which suddenly changes to a minor key, adds an ominous tone to the future of the couple that has just met. As such, from the very beginning, artificial lighting and constructed shadows play a significant role to develop the narrative and formulate certain moods for the scenes in *Cat People.*

We should note one more significant thing in this opening scene: it shows that Oliver is the kind of man who starts flirting with another woman without a word to the woman he is with. There is a woman right next to Oliver, drinking Coca-Cola with him. We only see her back, but her suit, blonde hair, and hairstyle indicate that this is Alice (Jane Randolph), who appears again later in the film. Alice is Oliver's colleague at the marine engineering office, and she is secretly in love with him. While a love triangle will be formed along the way,



A dark shadow appears on Irena's sketch of a black panther.

there is no shadow cast on Alice, a very cheerful woman, at this opening scene. She simply stands under the sun in this exterior scene, in flat lighting (even lighting on a subject, producing little contrast or shadow).

The shadows become thicker after Irena and Oliver enter the apartment building where Irena lives. In a long shot of the two standing at the entrance, the handrail of a long staircase and the window frames create strong lattice-shaped shadows on their faces and bodies because of the sunlight coming in from the windows. Irena has been joyfully conversing with Oliver up to this point but shows her first hesitation in those shadows. "I've never had anyone here. You're the first friend I meet [sic] in America. Oh, I know lots of people in business. Editors, secretaries, other sketch artists, you know. But you might be my first real friend." Irena's words signal her shyness and anxiety at being alone with a man in a foreign land. Oliver, though, is enraptured by the fact that he has been invited into an apartment by a woman whom he has just met. He merely smiles at Irena.

The first close-up of Irena in this film follows. This may be regarded as an image of how Irena appears in Oliver's eyes. This is because all the shadows on her face in the previous long shot are completely gone. Three-point lighting, which Hollywood cinema perfected in the 1920s in order to show off the beauty and glamour of their stars, makes Irena's hair, eyes, and face glow softly but gorgeously. Three-point lighting consists of three lights—key light, fill light, and backlight. The key light brings the primary light to the subject and highlights the form and dimension of it. It is not

Long shot of Irena and Oliver in the shadowy apartment building.

placed directly in front of the subject but instead slightly off to the side. The hard (or focused) key light clearly illuminates the contours of the subject, in this case, Irena's face, and creates the splendor of her eyes. But as it is, the rectangular angle of the light beam in relation to the subject also creates darkly shaded areas on the subject, in this case on Irena's face, because of her nose, cheekbones, etc. The fill light, usually a soft and indirect supplementary light that does not change the character of the key light, is used to erase darkly shaded areas on the subject, in this case again Irena's face. The fill light is usually placed at a vertical angle to the key light. The fill light allows room for controlling the appearance of the subject. The dimmer the fill light is, the harsher the subject looks. In this case, Irena's face does not look harsh at all, compared to the more contrasty long shot that precedes. Finally, the backlight, which is placed behind the subject at a slightly higher angle in order not to be seen by the camera, distinguishes the subject from her background and provides a sense of three-dimensionality. In this case, Irena's face is clearly distinguished from the darker background. In addition, and more importantly, the backlight gives a halo effect to her hair. Along with the glamorous effect that the three-point lighting brings to this close-up of Irena's face, a romantic tune is heard.

Casablanca (Michael Curtiz, 1942), which was released in the same year as *Cat People,* is another film that utilizes three-point lighting effectively in order to depict the glamour of the heroine. Ilsa (Ingrid Bergman) tells Sam the pianist (Dooley Wilson), "Play it, Sam," and implores him to play

Close-up of Irena in three-point lighting.

"As Time Goes By." Hearing the tune that he has forbidden Sam to play, Rick storms over in fury. There he sees Ilsa in a close-up. A spotlight illuminates her eyes, which are blurred by tears, and her lips, which are slightly open; a fill light softly embraces her face, and a backlight gives an almost sacred glow to the blonde hair of Bergman, who was originally from Northern Europe. In the background, we hear more romanticized orchestral sound swelling over the sound of Sam's piano, hinting that Rick is idealizing Ilsa here.

In *Cat People,* Irena does not stay in the soft three-point light for long. As soon as she opens the door of her apartment and the two enter, we move to the next scene. Irena's room is in darkness. Weak light from streetlamps and a building across the street enters the room through windows at the back. A statue of a man on horseback on a table is in silhouette. The man holds a raised sword, upon which a cat is speared. Standing by the table, Irena hums a gentle tune and explains. The man on the horse is King John of Serbia. The cat pierced by his sword is a symbol of the Mumluks, who worshiped Satan and made the people slaves. When King John drove out the Mumluks, some escaped into dark mountain villages. Irena says she is a descendent of one of those villages, which has become steeped in the legends of witchcraft. She murmurs, "I like the dark. It's friendly." Contrary to the ideal image created by the three-point lighting, presumably from Oliver's point of view, Irena appears to be herself in shadows.

Indeed, cats love dark places. Cats are nocturnal. They are more active during nighttime hours than during the day. Cats are originally from mountains and forests, where the sunlight is dim. Anyone who has lived with a cat has experienced finding his or her cat sleeping in a closet or a drawer. Surprising but funny. They feel very comfortable in those dark places, and the black pupils of their eyes become wide open and round. They look cute, but if we see them on a dark street, their gleaming eyes can be scary, too.

Unlike the glamorous splendor of the three-point lighting in the previous scene, Irena is here lit by so-called Lasky lighting, in which not only light but also shadow are conspicuous. As in a Rembrandt painting, a spotlight is directed to a limited area within a frame, which not only creates clear shadows but also indicates the source and direction of light. Around 1915, when cinema was silent, Cecil B. DeMille, who would later direct such spectacular films as *The Ten Commandments* (1956), and his cinematographer Alvin Wyckoff developed a lighting style with strong contrasts in order to create dramatic effects in cinema. Adopting carbon-arc equipment, such as Kliegl spotlights (called klieg lights), in particular, DeMille and Wyckoff moved the film lighting practice in Hollywood away from a dominant use of diffused, overall illumination toward a concentration on "effects" lighting (Bordwell,

Sessue Hayakawa in Lasky Lighting.

Steiger, and Thompson 1985, 223). In particular, they used "spotlights . . . to produce low-key lighting effects in several productions" (Bordwell, Steiger, and Thompson 1985, 224–225). Their lighting style was called Lasky lighting, which film historian Lea Jacobs defines as "confined and shallow areas of illumination, sharp-edged shadows and a palpable sense of the directionality of light" (Jacobs 1993, 408).

DeMille and Wyckoff had contracts with the Jesse L. Lasky Feature Play Company at that time. DeMille had a background in theater and brought the lighting techniques of the theatrical stage to cinema. Lasky lighting was directly derived from a popular theater lighting style developed by David Belasco, who was inspired by Rembrandt's treatment of light that emphasized the source of light from windows, lamps, or fires and created a dark atmosphere. Sessue Hayakawa became the biggest Asian star in the history of Hollywood cinema in part because of Lasky lighting. In *The Cheat* (1915), a masterpiece by DeMille and Wyckoff, dramatic lighting with strong contrasts enhanced the exotic and mysterious atmosphere surrounding Hayakawa's villain, giving a pleasurable shock to many female spectators.

Despite the impact of Lasky lighting, it did not become the mainstream lighting of Hollywood cinema because the contrasts of light and shadow it created were too extreme. By the 1920s, the majority of Hollywood lighting had become bright and soft, without conspicuous contrast between lights and shadow. Three-point lighting emerged as part of that trend. While major characters and props that viewers should not overlook are clearly visible, such lighting is not so obvious that viewers are even aware of it, which

focuses attention on the story of the film. Lasky lighting that emphasized shadows fell into a secondary position, used to add effects to gangster genres, among others, that Warner Bros. was particularly good at.

In the 1940s, when *Cat People* was produced, Lasky lighting was revived in the films that would later be called "film noir," which I will discuss in more detail in chapter five. In film noir, the lighting was favorably used to dramatically and realistically express the obsession or insanity of protagonists who often became involved with urban crimes. RKO Radio, which produced *Cat People,* also produced a number of films noirs.

In *Cat People,* Lasky lighting is effectively used in Irena's room. Behind Irena, Goya's 1784 painting, *Boy with Cats* (*Manuel Osorio Manrique de Zúñiga*), hangs on the wall; in it, three cats gaze at a little bird from the dark. Their eyes glow ominously, lit by a spotlight. In the following close-up of Irena's face, her left eye is strongly lit and shines ominously. The shining eyes of the cats and Irena form some kind of a connection in the dark. Such lighting makes us, the viewers, wonder whether the story about witches and cat people is only Irena's wild fantasy, or not.

After this scene, the love affair between the heroine and the hero literally turns into a battle between light and shadow. It is also one of three-point

Irena in front of a Goya painting.

Irena's left eye is strongly lit and shines ominously.

lighting versus Lasky lighting under the strict scheme of cinematographer Nicholas Musuraca, who would work on a number of masterpieces of film noir after this film, including *Out of the Past* (1947), directed by Jacques Tourneur. Can Oliver become Irena's "first real friend"? Can he live with her in the dark that she likes? Or, is he going to make her into the ideal shining image that he has of her? And will he forcefully try to bring her into the bright world that he likes?

Then the clock shows six o'clock. Oliver realizes that he has stayed too long. He promises to have dinner with Irena the following day and leaves her room. A truce. The battle of love and the battle of light and shadow have just begun.

Oliver Likes Bright Places

Unlike Irena's dark apartment, Oliver's marine engineering office is very bright. Except for the soft shadows of the circular frames of the chic, high windows, created by the sunlight on the wall, the spacious room is lit brightly and flatly. This is a typical lighting scheme of 1930s Hollywood cinema. A number of people are working cheerfully in the room. Alice is one of them. She notices a kitten's meow. (In fact, the kitten's voice is played by actress Dorothy Lloyd. She is a cat person.) Alice finds a shoebox on Oliver's drawing board and a white kitten inside it. He intends it as a gift for Irena—a bit insensitive, perhaps, for a woman suffering from a "cat curse."

Oliver's bright office.

We quickly learn that there is another cat in Oliver's office. Its name is John Paul Jones, after the American Revolutionary War hero. It is a perfect name for the office cat of a marine engineering firm. At the same time, the name symbolically expresses an American attitude toward foreigners, represented by Oliver. This film never refers explicitly to contemporary political issues. But the time was 1942, in the middle of World War II. The House Un-American Activities Committee (HUAC), which was originally created in 1938, was investigating alleged disloyalty and subversive activities. Anti-foreigner sentiments were stirring. At the same time, a pedagogical policy, or a desire of conquest, to Americanize immigrants from foreign countries, existed. Consciously or not, Oliver, as a typical white American man, seems to have this type of attitude toward Irena. It is true that this film depicts Oliver in a slightly critical manner. This might be because Val Lewton, the producer of this film, was an immigrant from Russia and had experienced discrimination as a foreigner in American society.

Irena has been living in the dark and is anxious about entering the bright world where Oliver lives. But Oliver does not listen to her. "You're here in America. You're so normal, you're in love with me, Oliver Reed, a good plain Americano. You're so normal, you're gonna marry me and those fairy tales, you can tell them to our children. They'll love them." In order not to offend Oliver the American, does Irena the foreigner have to do what he says? America is bright and Serbia is dark, and never the twain shall meet?

"Moia sestra, moia sestra."

Will Oliver Learn to Like Dark Places?

In the following scene, Irena and Oliver are already married. They are in the midst of their wedding reception at Belgrade, the only Serbian restaurant in New York. Lots of candles stand on the table, which is brightly lit. Irena sits next to Oliver and smiles as "normal" newlywed brides do. It is as if bright America has enlightened dark Serbia.

But suddenly, the dark side strikes back. A woman from another table comes by and speaks to Irena in a foreign language. "Moia sestra, moia sestra," she says. She wears a black dress that shines like a black cat's fur and has a black ribbon in her hair, which looks like cat ears. Irena cannot say a word. With a vague smile, the woman puts a black, hairy scarf over her shoulders and slips out into the snowy, dark street outside. Oliver's colleague whispers, "Looks like a cat." At this moment, Irena clearly remembers that she is not living in the same world as Oliver. With a frozen expression, she says to Oliver, "She called me sister." Because of the appearance of the cat person, their wedding turns out not to be "normal."

Even though it is their wedding night, Irena and Oliver do not sleep together. They do not even kiss each other. In their darkened apartment, a tightly closed door separates them. In Lasky lighting, Irena leans against that door and sits down. She puts her right-hand fingernails onto the door, as cats often do with their claws. A cat's meow is heard from somewhere, too.

Irena sits in a shadow.

"But I want to be Mrs. Reed, really," she says. "I want to be everything that name means to me. And I can't. I can't. Oliver, be kind, be patient. Let me have time. Time to get over that feeling there's something evil in me."

On the other side of the door, in brighter light, Oliver replies, "Darling, you can have all the time there is in the world if you want it and all the patience and kindness there is in me."

But, after all, Oliver cannot be patient enough to wait for this creature from the dark.

Even though she asks Oliver to wait, Irena becomes more and more feline-like after the wedding night. Has her true nature been revealed despite her wish? Or, is she hoping that Oliver will accept her as she is? In any case, the costume, the props, and above all the lighting emphasize her approach to the dark side. Irena starts to wear a short-haired black fur coat, similar to the one the cat person at the restaurant wore. When she visits a museum with Oliver and Alice, she goes close to a statue of Bastet, a cat goddess of ancient Egypt. (In the film, we actually see a statue of Anubis, a jackal-headed god. The director wanted Bastet, but the prop department could not find one.) When she works as a dress designer, she makes a sketch of the cat woman from the restaurant. One day, during her work, she casually stands up, sticks her left hand into a birdcage hung beside a window, and plays with a canary inside. Irena's face is shown in a close-up, and her right eye shines ominously. Her white teeth are slightly visible, too. Cats become excited when they see insects or birds; their pupils dilate and they show their teeth. What we the

Irena stands near a statue of Anubis.

viewers see next is a shot of the canary lying dead in the cage. Did Irena kill it unexpectedly with her hand, just as cats kill other creatures without knowing it when they play with them?

Seeing Irena acting strange, Oliver recommends that she see a psychiatrist called Dr. Judd. He wants Irena to be able to lead a "normal" life in American society. Dr. Judd uses bright lights for the treatment. When he asks questions of Irena, he places a strong, tight spotlight on her face while she lies in the dark.

"You were saying, the cats . . ." he begins, prompting her.

Irena answers with her eyes closed. "They torment me. I wake in the night and the tread of their feet whispers in my brain. I have no peace for they are in me. In me. In me."

After hearing this, Dr. Judd opens the curtain and stands beside Irena in the bright light from outside. "And the cat women of your village, too. You told me of them. Women who, in jealousy or anger or out of their own corrupt passions, can change into great cats, like panthers. And if one of these women were to fall in love and if her lover were to kiss her, take her into his embrace, she would be driven by her own evil to kill him. That's what you believe and fear, isn't it?"

Irena nods.

Window frames create a cross-shaped shadow on the wall. Dr. Judd, taking notes in front of it, looks like a priest with the Bible in his hand. Irena, sitting on a sofa beside him, looks like a believer who needs his guidance.

Irena's face is placed under a strong and tight spotlight.

Jealousy, anger, and passion. These emotions wait for Irena when she comes back from the doctor's office. She opens the door of her apartment and finds the room brighter than usual. She sees Alice lighting her cigarette at the back of the room. While she was away, brightness has been brought into her room by another woman and replaced the darkness that she loves. Irena also finds out that Dr. Judd, who conducts the light treatment, was actually recommended by Alice. At this moment, Irena realizes she is facing an enemy. She wants to face the darkness in her only with Oliver. But light has invaded in the shape of another woman.

Alice Does Not Like Dark Places

For Irena, Alice becomes an enemy. But to us, the viewers, this is not really true. Rather, Oliver is the one who is to blame. He told Irena that she could have all the time in the world, but after only a short while, he says to Alice, "I've never been unhappy before," and "I don't even know whether I'm in love with Irena." Alice replies right away, "I can't bear to see you unhappy. I love you too darn much, and I don't care if you do know it, Ollie." Here a close-up with the three-point lighting appears again. As in the first close-up of Irena, Alice's blonde hair and tearful eyes shine beautifully. Shown in such an enchanting manner, Alice captures Oliver's heart as well as ours. Alice is not a bitch who steals Oliver from Irena, however. She is always cheerful and loves Oliver earnestly. She is the other heroine of this film. So we sympathize with her.

Alice stands beside an illuminated table.

Irena stops seeing Dr. Judd. It is natural for her to do so because Dr. Judd was recommended by her rival in love. But Oliver loses his temper when he finds out. He says he has some work to do and leaves their apartment. Irena makes up with him and calls his office. It is Alice who picks up the phone. Alice's worktable has a light bulb inside that illuminates her face brightly. In contrast, Irena hangs up in darkness without a word. She puts on her black fur coat and leaves the apartment with a hard expression. Alice also leaves the office. When she turns off the table light, she places herself in the dark for the first time in this film.

Alice finds Oliver at a café nearby and joins him. It is the worst possible timing. Irena passes by on her way to their office, looks through the window, and sees Oliver and Alice sitting together. Half of her face is hidden behind the curtain and window frame. Her left eye is ominously lit by the light from the café. The Lasky lighting emphasizes the fire of jealousy.

The shot that follows clearly shows Irena's reflection on the window, which makes it look as though Irena is split into two figures. Does the cat woman reveal itself from inside Irena's body? As closing time approaches, a waitress starts turning off lamps in the café. The office and then the café—both places that are usually bright—gradually go dark. Irena makes sure that the couple leaves the café and goes out onto the dark sidewalk.

As if protecting themselves from the dark, Oliver and Alice stop at the bright spot right under a street lamp.

"You cold?" he asks her.

Irena spots Oliver and Alice, and her eye is fired by jealousy.

Irena is split into two figures.

"A cat just walked over my grave."

Waving goodbye to Oliver, Alice walks into the shadow of Central Park. Now the climactic chase begins. The lighting persistently emphasizes the contrast between light and shadow. The editing creates an intense tempo between the woman who chases and the woman who is being chased. (We will focus on editing in chapter three.) Moreover, the sound heightens tension and adds shock effects. These techniques make this chase scene truly tense, like watching a cat on a hot tin roof.

The camera first captures Alice in a white coat in a long shot. She walks on the pavement, first passing through a lit area under a street lamp, then a dark area in shadow. The hard sound of her high heels on asphalt echoes. Then, the camera switches to Irena in her black fur coat as she follows Alice in a long shot. Exactly like Alice, she walks on the pavement, passing through a lit area under a street lamp and a dark area in shadow to the sound of her high heels. The shot that follows shows Alice's feet in a close-up. Her feet move continuously from light to shadow. We hear her high heels tapping on the pavement.

A close-up of Irena's feet follows. From light to shadow. The sound of high heels. Remembering the silent phone call to the office, Alice starts to feel frightened. She quickens her pace. Tap-tap-tap. Alice does not know who is following her. She does not even realize that Irena thinks of her as her enemy. But it is scary to be followed in the dark. Suddenly, the footsteps that have followed her stop. Noticing that, Alice stops under a street lamp and turns around. She walks again for a few feet and turns around again. All she can see is the deserted pavement, a street lamp, and the darkness. There is no sound at all. Panicked, she is about to start running.

All of a sudden, a hissing sound cuts through the air. At the same time, from the opposite direction, a bus rushes into the frame and makes a sudden stop. Together with Alice, our hearts seem to stop beating. The driver speaks to Alice in a cheerful voice from the bright inside.

"You look as if you'd seen a ghost."

But Alice does not have her usual gay attitude. She responds seriously, "Did you see it?" Then she climbs quickly into the brightly lit bus.

Alice walks.

Irena follows.

Alice gazes at the deserted pavement and the darkness.

After the bus leaves, a black bush sways above the stone wall beside the pavement. The Central Park Zoo is beyond the wall. There is a sheep cage there, in which an alarming event seems to be occurring. A caretaker comes out with a lantern. A sheep has been attacked. The camera goes back to the pavement under a street lamp, where we see the black footprints of a big cat. After a while, the prints change into those of high heels. At the same time, we start to hear the sound of footsteps again. Tap-tap-tap. Then,

Irena cries in a bathtub.

Irena appears out of the darkness. She is placing a white handkerchief on her mouth. Is she wiping away blood from a sheep that she has just attacked? All of a sudden, a taxi makes a quick stop nearby with a hissing sound, which makes us jump once again.

Coming back to the apartment, Irena finds Oliver there but ignores him. She takes off her stockings, fills the bathtub, and climbs in. Under the bright light of the bathroom, drops of water shine on her naked back. She holds her knees tightly and cries. It is a shocking revelation. She *is* a cat person. This is the first time that Irena voluntarily places herself under bright light, but she looks more distraught than ever. It seems as if she wants to be cleansed by the light. This is the most excruciating shot in this film.

In 1942, when *Cat People* was released, the content that could be shown in films was controlled by the Production Code. As discussed in the previous chapter, showing nudity on the screen was severely controlled. Film critic Kim Newman claims, "This affecting little vignette must have been fairly risqué for 1942: Simone Simon stripping her stockings and exposing a little naked back in a non-sexual situation wouldn't have counted as 'hot stuff' before the imposition of the Production Code in 1934, but here it indicates Lewton's intention to push the envelope on censorship" (Newman 1999, 46). Looking at Irena's naked back, people watching this film in 1942 must have felt that they had just seen what they should not. That makes this scene even more painful.

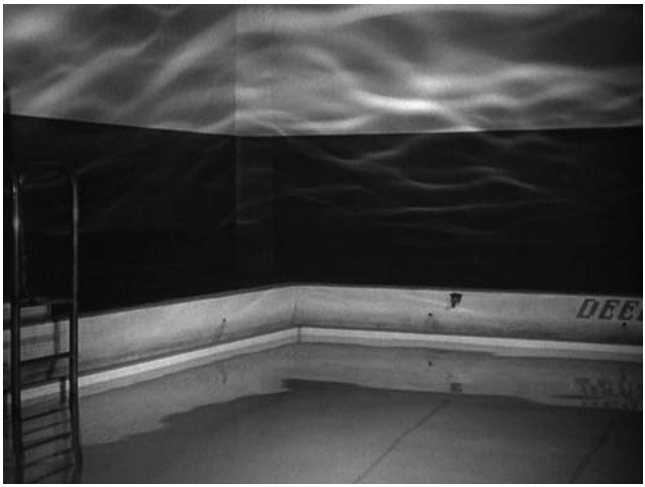
When the dark night falls, Irena cannot help chasing Alice again; it is, after all, a cat's nature to pursue its prey. Alice is going to exercise at a YWCA

swimming pool. A black cat follows her from the front desk when she goes downstairs to the locker room. Following the black cat, Irena in her black fur coat appears at the front desk without a sound and asks the woman there where she can find Alice. In the locker room, Alice, now in a bathing suit, happens to look up the stairway. She sees a moving shadow of a panther-like creature. The shadow is too big for the black cat at the front desk. Panicked, Alice jumps head first into the brightly lit pool. At that moment, the growl of a panther begins.

Floating in the middle of the pool, Alice looks around the poolside. The light leaking from the locker room is reflected on the water and creates various shadows on the walls and the ceiling. Those shadows ominously keep moving. The whole room becomes dark for a moment. Something has blocked the light from the locker room. It becomes light, and then dark again. Alice is desperately treading water and cannot clearly see what it is. All she can see is the light and the shadow swaying on the wall and the ceiling. A shot of Alice in the pool and a shot of the light and the shadow on the wall and the ceiling are repeated. The shot lengths become shorter and shorter. Then, a clear shadow of a panther moves at the poolside. (During the actual shooting, a panther was never used. Director Jacques Tourneur created the shadow with his fists.) Alice screams. A shot of the poolside. A shot of the light and the shadow on the ceiling. Alice desperately moves her arms and legs in panic. Because of Alice's frantic movements, the swaying light and shadow on the wall and the ceiling move much more quickly and haphazardly. All of a sudden, Irena appears at the poolside. She turns on the light and looks down at Alice.

"What is the matter, Alice?"

Alice screams in the swimming pool.



The light and the shadow swaying on the wall.

Cats hate water. Of course, there are some cats, including mine, that play with water dripping from faucets or scoop water from a bowl to drink. But I do not think there are many cats that like to bathe in a bathtub or in a swimming pool. I am sure that I'm not the only person who, trying to wash a cat in a bathtub, has been resisted with unbelievable strength, and has been scratched by their claws. Such experiences are traumatic for both cats and human beings.

Most likely because Alice was in the water, Irena could not catch her game again. Instead, Alice's bathrobe, left in the locker room, becomes the victim. It has been torn to pieces. Now Alice clearly knows. She is Irena's target, and Irena is a brutal cat woman.

Irena's Death: Can I Leave the Dark Place Now?

"I love Alice. Irena, it's too late . . . Well, there seems only one decent thing for me to do. I'll give you a divorce. Believe me, it's better this way," Oliver tells Irena when she comes home.

"Better? Better for whom?"

Oliver cannot answer. He leaves the dark apartment. Left alone, Irena crawls on hands and knees and buries her face in a sofa. Fire rises up in the fireplace. The contrast between light and shadow becomes stronger because of the firelight. At that moment, Irena's right fingers rip the sofa.

Oliver finds Alice at the office. Unlike Irena's dark room, the drawing table of his office emits bright light and illuminates them brightly. The phone

rings. Shortly after, a shadow of a panther appears on the office wall, and the growl is heard, too. Irena is back again to chase Alice. This time there is no place to escape—no bus and no swimming pool. The only thing in hand that can become a weapon is a t-shaped ruler for drawing. All Oliver and Alice can do is place themselves in the light and pray. As Kim Newman describes, "With the strong underlighting from the drafting tables shining merciless spotlights on Oliver and Alice as they back into a corner, the scene uses light as inventively as shadow to terrify. The cat inhabits pools of dark low-down in the room, prowling between items of furniture, but its potential prey are frozen in harsh, bright whiteness against the walls" (Newman 1999, 59).

Covered by the bright light from the drawing table, Oliver says. "Leave us, Irena. In the name of God, leave us in peace." The t-shaped ruler in his hand creates a cross-like shadow on the wall. The shadow of a panther circles around the couple in the bright light. Is she hesitating? For Irena, Alice is an enemy. But how about Oliver? She has hoped he would accept her as she is, someone who cannot help living in a dark place. She has tried to become fond of bright places so they could live a "normal" life together. After a little while, the shadow of the panther, or the shadow of Irena as a cat person, vanishes from the office as if it has forgiven the couple in the light.

Irena goes back home alone. But Dr. Judd waits for her there. Irena's face in a close-up is lit by the three-point lighting. It is a beautiful image of Irena as seen through Dr. Judd's lustful eyes. But in the extreme close-up of Irena's face that follows, the lighting has clearly changed. It is Lasky lighting

"Leave us, Irena. In the name of God, leave us in peace."

The t-shaped ruler in Oliver's hand creates a cross-like shadow on the wall.

Close-up of Irena in the three-point lighting.

with stronger contrasts. Irena's face is in shadow now. Ominous light dwells in her eyes. She has forgotten Oliver and spared Alice. But now she must face the one who uses light to hypnotize her and invades her territory of darkness. This is the final battle of shadow against light. A black shadow of a panther attacks Dr. Judd, who defends himself with a sword cane.

Fatally injured, Irena heads to the dark and misty Central Park Zoo. She opens the cage to let the black panther escape. Then she falls down.

Close-up of Irena in Lasky lighting.

Irena's body lies under the bright street lamp.

The blade of Dr. Judd's sword cane is in her shoulder and reflects light dully. Oliver and Alice arrive, and the love triangle ends where it all began. Irena's body is lying on the pavement under the bright street lamp. Only when she dies is she able to give herself to bright light.

Oliver murmurs, "She never lied to us." Only when she dies is she understood by Oliver. The panther that has escaped also dies. The moment he jumps out into the city of New York, he is hit by a car. Its dead body is also brightly lit by the car's headlight.

The two inhabitants of the bright world, Oliver and Alice, are united as an American couple. The monster from a foreign country who lives in the dark is gone. But is this a happy ending? In the end, Oliver could not believe. He could not wait. Fully utilizing artificial lighting and constructing shadows, *Cat People* tells a story about light and shadow that cannot live happily ever after.

Filmography

American in Paris, An (Vincent Minnelli, 1951)
Ants (*Ari-chan,* Seo Mitsuyo, 1941)
Avatar (James Cameron, 2009)
Ball at the Anjo House, The (*Anjō ke no butōkai,* Yoshimura Kōzaburō, 1947)
Bambi (David Hand, James Algar, Bill Roberts, Norman Wright, Samuel Armstrong, Paul Satterfield, Graham Heid, 1942)
Battleship Potemkin (Sergei Eisenstein, 1925)
Big Sleep, The (Howard Hawks, 1946)
Birth of a Nation, The (D.W. Griffith, 1915)
Black Cat Mansion (*Bōrei kaibyō yashiki,* Nakagawa Nobuo, 1958)
Blade Runner (Ridley Scott, 1982)
Blonde Venus (Josef von Sternberg, 1932)
Blue Angel, The (Der blau Engel, Josef von Sternberg, 1930)
Boxing Cats, The (Thomas Edison, 1894)
Breakfast at Tiffany's (Blake Edwards, 1961)
Bringing Up Baby (Howard Hawks, 1938)
Casablanca (Michael Curtiz, 1942)
Cat People (Jacques Tourneur, 1942)
Cats of Mirikitani, The (Linda Hattendorf, 2006)
Cheat, The (Cecil B. DeMille, 1915)
Children's Hour, The (William Wyler, 1961)
Chutaro of Banba: Mother of Memory (*Banba no Chūtarō: Mabuta no haha,* Inagaki Hiroshi, 1931)
Citizen Kane (Orson Welles, 1940)
Crucified Lovers, The (*Chikamatsu monogatari,* Mizoguchi Kenji, 1954)
Dark Night's Passing, A (*An'ya kōro,* Toyoda Shirō, 1959)
Day for Night (*La Nuit américaine,* François Truffaut, 1973)
Devil Is a Woman, The (Josef von Sternberg, 1935)
Dishonored (Josef von Sternberg, 1931)

Don't Bother to Knock (Roy Ward Baker, 1952)
Double Indemnity (Billy Wilder, 1944)
Female Genealogy (*Onna keizu,* Makino Masahiro, 1942)
Fight Club (David Fincher, 1999)
Galaxy Express 999 (Ginga *tetsudō 999,* Rintarō, 1979)
Gate of Hell (*Jigokumon,* Kinugasa Teinosuke, 1954)
Ghost Cat of Otama Pond (*Kaibyō Otamagaike,* Ishikawa Yoshirō, 1960)
Ghost of Saga Mansion (*Kaidan Saga yashiki,* Arai Ryōhei, 1953)
Godfather, The (Francis Ford Coppola, 1972)
Great Train Robbery, The (Edwin S. Porter, 1903)
I Am a Cat (*Wagahai wa neko dearu,* Ichikawa Kon, 1975)
Inchon (Terence Young, 1981)
Jungle Emperor Leo (*Janguru taitei,* Takeuchi Yoshio, 1997)
La Bête humaine (Jean Renoir, 1938)
Lady from Shanghai, The (Orson Welles, 1948)
Lady in the Lake (Robert Montgomery, 1947)
Laura (Otto Preminger, 1944)
Lion King, The (Roger Allers and Rob Minkoff, 1994)
Little Girl and Her Cat, The (*La Petite fille et son chat,* director unknown, 1900)
Love of Actress Sumako, The (*Joyū Sumako no koi,* Mizoguchi Kenji, 1947)
Magnificent Ambersons, The (Orson Welles, 1942)
Maltese Falcon, The (John Huston, 1941)
Mark of Zorro, The (Fred Niblo, 1920)
Morocco (Josef von Sternberg, 1930)
No Regrets for Our Youth (*Waga seishun ni kui nashi,* Kurosawa Akira, 1946)
North by Northwest (Alfred Hitchcock, 1959)
Osaka Elegy (*Naniwa erejī,* Mizoguchi Kenji, 1936)
Out of the Past (Jacques Tourneur, 1947)
Pawnbroker, The (Sydney Lumet, 1964)
Peachboy's Sea-eagle (*Momotarō no umiwashi,* Seo Mitsuyo, 1943)
Period that Toyo Miyatake Looked into, The (*Tōyō Miyatake ga nozoita jidai,* Suzuki Junichi, 2008)
Pink Panther, The (Blake Edwards, 1963)
Port of Shadows, The (*Le Quai des brumes,* Marcel Carné, 1938)
Private Life of a Cat, The (Alexander Hammid and Maya Deren, 1944)
Rashomon (*Rashōmon,* Kurosawa Akira, 1950)
Roman Holiday (William Wyler, 1953)
Rope (Alfred Hitchcock, 1948)
Sabrina (Billy Wilder, 1954)
Samurai Cat (*Neko zamurai,* Yamaguchi Yoshitaka and Watanabe Takeshi, 2014)
Samurai Cat 2: A Tropical Adventure (*Neko zamurai 2: Minami no shima e iku,* Watanabe Takeshi, 2015)
Sansho the Bailiff (*Sanshō dayu,* Mizoguchi Kenji, 1954)
Season of the Sun (*Taiyō no kisetsu,* Furukawa Takumi, 1956)

Seven Samurai (*Shichinin no samurai,* Kurosawa Akira, 1954)
Shanghai Express (Josef von Sternberg, 1932)
Shozo, a Cat and Two Women, A (*Neko to Shōzō to futari no onna,* Toyoda Shirō, 1956)
Sisters of the Gion (*Gion no kyōdai,* Mizoguchi Kenji, 1936)
Snow Country (*Yukiguni,* Toyoda Shirō, 1957)
Snow White and Seven Dwarfs (David Hand, Larry Morey, Wilfred Jackson, Ben Sharpsteen, Perce Pearce, William Cottrell, 1938)
Star Wars (George Lucas, 1977)
Steamboat Willie (Walt Disney and Ub Iwerks, 1928)
Strange Tale of Oyuki, The (*Bokutō kidan,* Toyoda Shirō, 1960)
Take Care of My Cat (*Goyangireul Butakhae,* Jeong Jae-eun, South Korea, 2001)
Tale of the White Serpent, The (*Hakujaden,* Yabushita Taiji and Ōkawa Hiroshi, 1956)
Ten Commandments (Cecil B. DeMille, 1956)
That Darn Cat! (Robert Stevenson, 1965)
Third Man, The (Carol Reed, 1949)
To Catch a Thief (Alfred Hitchcock, 1955)
Tojuro's Love (*Tōjurō no koi,* Yamamoto Kajirō, 1937)
Tsuruhachi Tsurujirō (Naruse Mikio, 1938)
Ugetsu (*Ugetsu monogatari,* Mizoguchi Kenji, 1953)
Water Magician, The (*Taki no shiraito,* Mizoguchi Kenji, 1933)
Wild Geese, The (*Gan,* Toyoda Shirō, 1953)
Wolf Man, The (George Wagner, 1941)
Woman in the Window, The (Fritz Lang, 1944)
World of Susie Wong, The (Richard Kwan, 1959)
Yojimbo (*Yōjimbō,* Kurosawa Akira, 1961)

An extensive list of films with cats can be found on such websites as "Cinema Cats: From Feline Film Stars to Kitty Cameos." http://www.cinemacats.com

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